

Introduction

Thematic roles approach [2]

Agent, Cause, Instrument, Experiencer, Theme, Patient, etc.

Proto-Roles approach [1]

Proto-Agent and **Proto-Patient**

Psycholinguistic evidence shows that Agents have different processing correlates than Themes [5]. Experiencer processing has not been investigated yet.

Has the Experiencer thematic role a specific processing pattern?

In order to determine this, we investigated argument structures with Experiencer role [3, 4]:

Psych verbs

Experiencer-Theme

e.g. *love*

Agent-Experiencer

e.g. *frighten*

Perceptual verbs

Experiencer-Theme

e.g. *observe*

Methods

Eye-tracking

48 Spanish native speakers (M=21 years).

Reading task

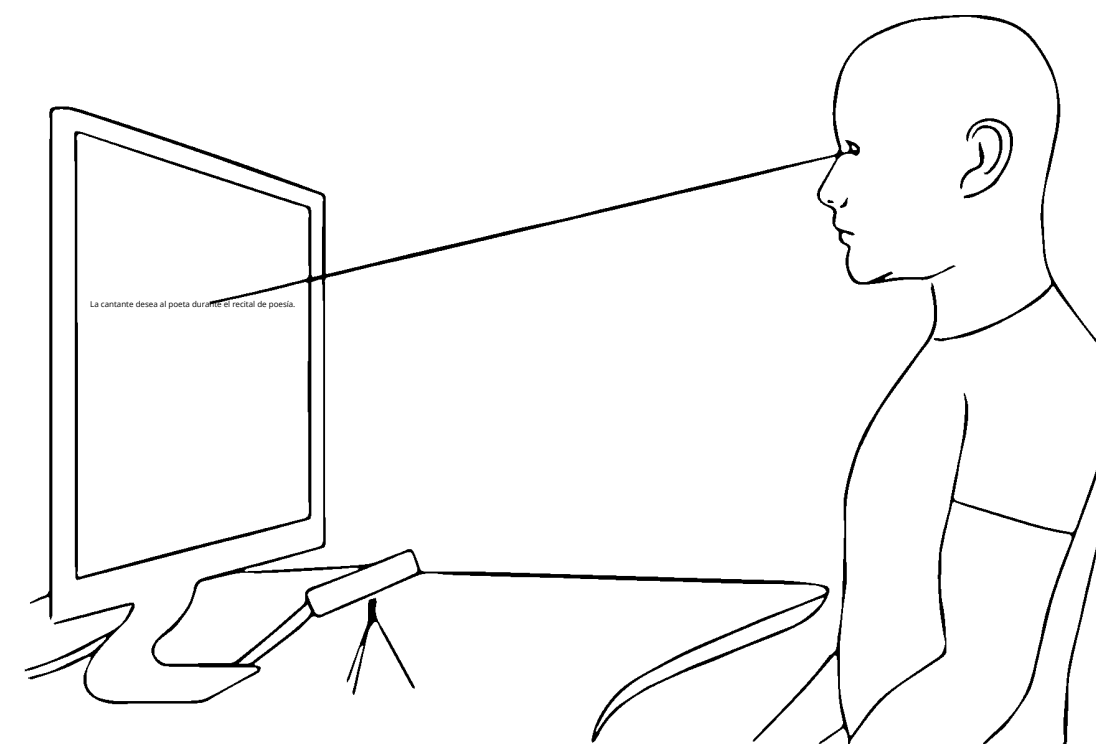
20 verbs per condition controlled by length and frequency.

40 experimental items and 80 fillers.

2x2 repeated measures design:

Verb Type (Psych vs. Non-psych)

Argument Structure (Experiencer-Theme vs. Agent-Theme/Experiencer)



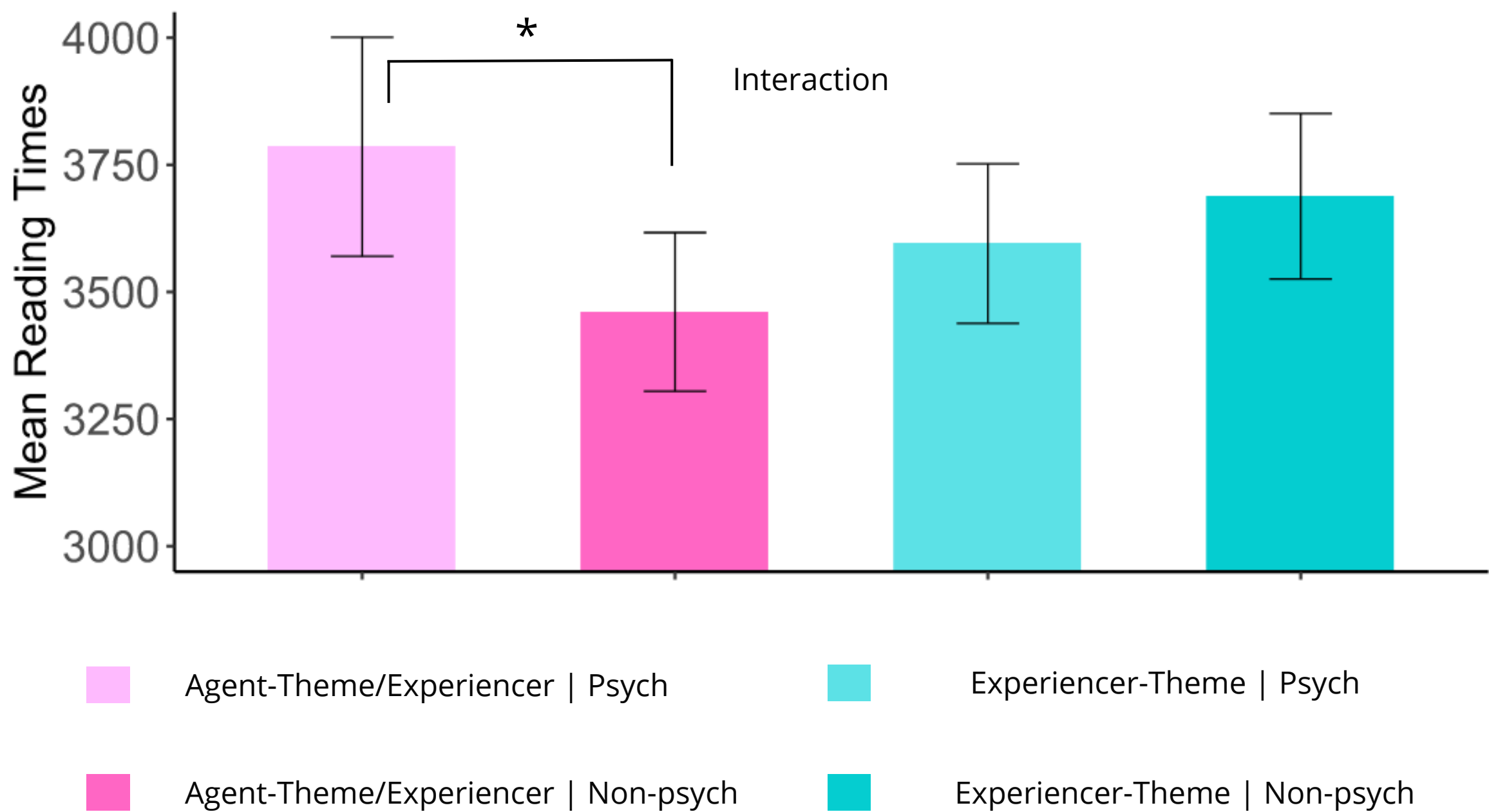
Materials

Verb Type	Argument Structure	Subject Region	Verb Region	Object Region	Post-object Region	Last-word Region
Psych	Experiencer-Theme	La cantante	desea	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Psych	Agent-Experiencer	La cantante	enamora	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Experiencer-Theme	La cantante	contempla	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.
Non-psych	Agent-Theme	La cantante	abandona	al poeta	durante el recital de	poesía.

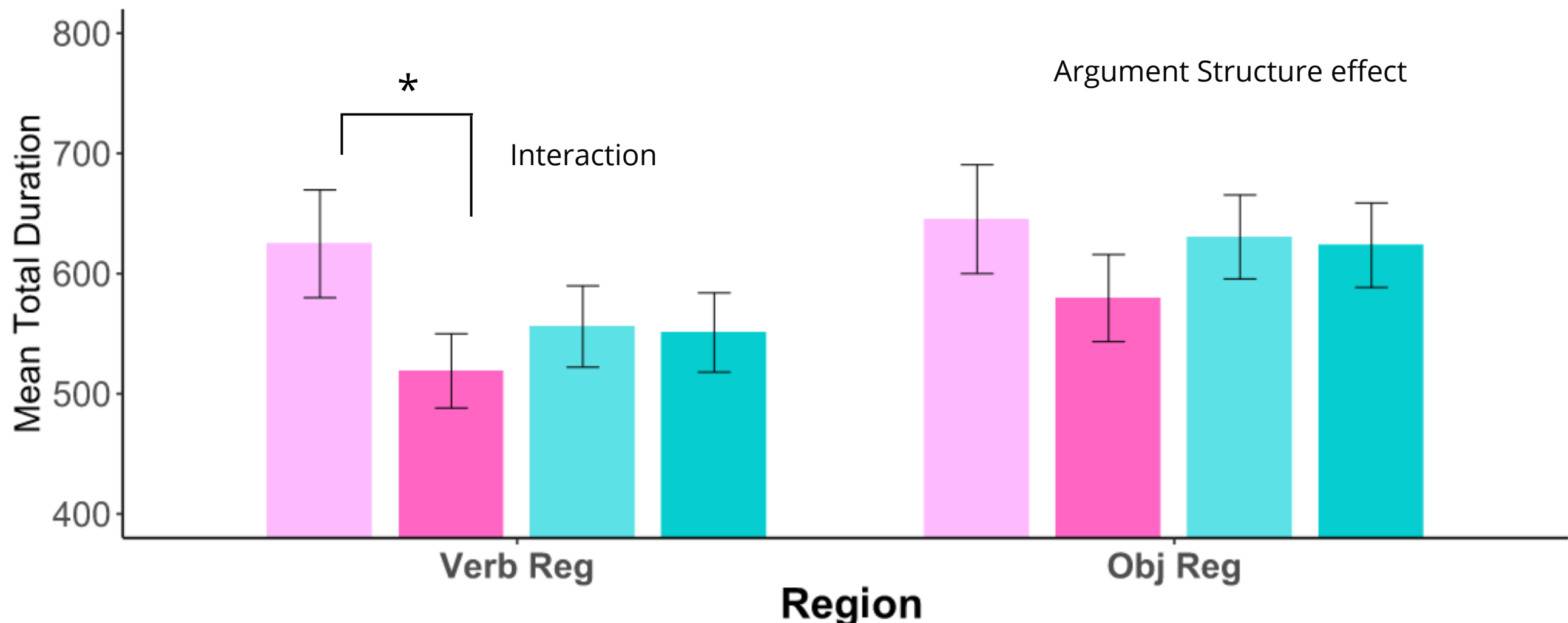
The singer /desires/contemplates/makes fall in love/abandons /the poet/during the poetry/recital.

Results

Reading Times (ms)



Total Duration (ms)



Discussion and Conclusion

Experiencer role involves **increased processing load**. It is not a prototypical Agent [1].

Agent-Experiencer structures have two arguments that are candidates to be Proto-Agent, increasing difficulty to process compared to prototypical Agent-Theme structures.

Experiencer-Theme structures do not have significant differences compared to Agent-Theme.

We conclude that **Experiencer role fits into Proto-Agent category**; it is candidate to be Proto-Agent. This involves processing difficulties in **Agent-Experiencer** structures trying to determine which participant is the Proto-Agent.

References

- [1] Dowty, D. (1991). Thematic proto-roles and argument selection. *Language*, 67(3), 547-619.
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- [4] Pesetsky, D. M. (1996). *Zero Syntax: Experiencers and Cascades*. MIT Press.
- [5] Rissman, L., & Majid, A. (2019). Thematic roles: Core knowledge or linguistic construct? *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*, 26(6), 1850-1869.

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